We separate our environments using different catalogs. Most of this book's project work occurs using the `ml_in_action` catalog. For the production version of some models, we use the `ml_in_prod` catalog. Setting up multiple workspaces is another way to separate environments. We recommend using documentation and your company policies to guide your isolation setup. Let's move on to what precisely a workspace is in the context of Databricks.

Defining a workspace

It's important to know that Databricks uses the word **workspace** to refer to two distinct components: an instance of Databricks (meaning your hosted Databricks deployment that you access via your unique URL address) and the folder environment for accessing your work products, like notebooks, queries, and dashboards.

Let's go through the two components:

- **Workspace as an instance**: A Databricks account can have multiple workspaces attached to it, meaning instances of the DI Platform are deployed and often accessible from a browser, as mentioned previously, but are also accessible via an SDK or a REST API.
- **Workspace as a folder**: Workspace also refers to the folder that contains your user's home folder, repositories, projects, and a shared folder that is visible to all users on the workspace instance. Often, users set their main system path to their `Workspace` folder to store their MLFlow experiments or Terraform states for pipeline deployment. You can also create and store notebooks outside source control in your home and project folders.

We now have a clearer understanding of a workspace. Now let's discuss why we choose **Unity Catalog** (**UC**) as our preferred metastore.

Selecting the metastore

A metastore is a system that stores metadata for a data platform and can be thought of as the top-level container of objects. It registers a variety of information about databases, tables, views, **User-Defined Functions** (**UDFs**), and other data assets. Metadata includes details such as storage location and the permissions that govern access to each asset.

Two types of metastores are natively available in the DI Platform: **Unity Catalog** (**UC**) and the **Hive Metastore** (**HMS**). UC has a three-level namespace consisting of a catalog, a database (also called a schema), and a table name. In contrast, the HMS only uses a two-level namespace containing just a database and table name. A metastore is required for your Databricks Workspace instance, as this is the component that organizes and governs data access. Deciding on the right metastore is an early decision in your DI Platform journey, and we recommend Unity Catalog. Let's talk about why.